Scouts

27 May 2026 – Cecilia to Kirstenbosch Ramble

Time	Activity and venue	Leader	Equipment
Beforehand	Advise Cubs to bring: • Water • Hats • Bright coloured tops – "we are covering emergency signaling" • Torch • Snack	Mang	Clip boards, Indemnity Forms, First Aid Kit
5:30 - 5:35	Grand Howl Duty six: YELLOW SIX Birthdays	Akela	
5:35 - 5:45	Explain to cubs: Buddy system. Check equipment Hiking rules Cub outdoor code • I will do my best to protect and care for wildlife, trees and flowers. • I will do my best to keep the countryside, roads and beaches free of litter.	Mang	Rubbish bags & gloves for scouters
5:40 - 6:20	Walk from Cecilia to Kirstenbosch Gate 3 Who are Silver wolves? Put up your hand? Pause to listen to sounds and look at nature along the way. Silver Wolves should look for interesting natural objects, plants and animals. (leaves, seeds, berries, stones, feathers)	Mang	Trail map
6:20 - 6:40	Silver wolves (part of *Silver Wolf Outdoor Challenge*) What did we find? Show leaders what was found/collected. What did we hear? Close eyes at the top and listen.	Akela & adult leaders	Top of contour path

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6:20 - 6:40	Gold wolves - Activity: lost in the veld Discuss what to do when lost in the veld: stop, think, shelter, signal, save supplies, be patient, let people know where you are What kinds of things could happen? Table mountain - separated, lost, rain/mist, snakes (puff adders). Distress Signals: ● Torch, use hands to cover and make 3 flashes. SOS in morse code, 3 long followed by 3 short flashes ● Jackets spread out on ground - bright colors hopefully ● Noise - shouting/whistle ● Listen - 1 minute	Mang and adult leaders	Top of contour path
6:40	If there is time: find out if cubs know where the sun rises and sets	Mang	Bring green laser light
6:40 - 7:20	Return via Kirstenbosch Gate 3: pickup Remember buddy system	Mang	
7:20 - 7:30	Closing Grand Howl Announcements	Akela	

Advancement: https://scoutwiki.scouts.org.za/wiki/Cub_Outdoor_Challenge_-_Hiking
Silver Wolf:

- Understand and practice the Outdoor Code
- Go on a nature ramble with your Pack. Listen to and identify sounds. Look for and identify, if possible, some interesting natural objects.

Gold wolf

- Explain what to do if lost in the veld
- Discuss natural dangers you find in the veld
- Go on a day hike and know what to wear & take with you
- Demonstrate three ways of making distress signals

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A Walk Through Cecilia Forest — History and Context

Nestled on the eastern slopes of Table Mountain, Cecilia Forest is one of the oldest and most historically significant forested areas in Cape Town. Today it is loved for its shaded walking trails, streams, and mountain scenery, but the forest also tells an important story about colonial settlement, timber use, conservation, and the changing relationship between people and nature on the Cape Peninsula.

Early Indigenous Landscape

Long before colonial settlement, the slopes around Cecilia Forest formed part of the seasonal movement routes of the indigenous Khoi pastoralists and San hunter-gatherers. The mountain streams supplied fresh water, while the surrounding vegetation provided grazing, medicinal plants, and shelter. The original vegetation of the area consisted largely of Afrotemperate forest patches mixed with fynbos, both uniquely adapted to the Cape's Mediterranean climate.

Colonial Farming and the Origin of the Name

The name "Cecilia" dates back to the 18th century and is linked to the historic Groot Constantia estate nearby. The land formed part of the extensive farming properties granted during the Dutch colonial period. Cecilia Forest itself is believed to have been named after Cecilia, daughter of one of the early landowners connected to the Constantia wine farms.

During the 1700s and 1800s, much of the indigenous forest in the Cape Peninsula was harvested for timber. Wood was in high demand for building materials, wagon construction, fuel, and ship repairs. As settlement expanded, the natural forests became increasingly depleted.

Plantation Forestry

By the late 19th century, colonial authorities recognised that indigenous forests could not sustain the growing demand for timber. Large areas of Cecilia were replanted with fast-growing exotic trees, especially pine, eucalyptus, and gum species. These commercial plantations supplied timber to Cape Town for decades and dramatically changed the appearance of the mountain slopes.

Many of the tall pine trees still seen in parts of Cecilia Forest today are remnants of this plantation era. While these trees are not indigenous, they have become part of the cultural memory of generations of walkers, runners, and mountain users.

Water and the Mountain Catchment

The eastern slopes of Table Mountain play a critical role as a water catchment area. Numerous streams flow through Cecilia Forest, feeding rivers and reservoirs that historically supplied water to farms and later to the city of Cape Town. The cool, moist environment created ideal conditions for forest growth and contributed to the lush character that distinguishes Cecilia from the more open fynbos-covered slopes elsewhere on the mountain.

Conservation and Restoration

Today Cecilia Forest forms part of Table Mountain National Park, managed by South African National Parks. Conservation efforts over recent decades have focused on balancing recreation, biodiversity conservation, and the gradual restoration of indigenous vegetation.

One of the major ecological challenges has been the management of invasive alien trees. Although pines and gums have historical value, they consume large amounts of water and displace indigenous fynbos and

forest species. Controlled clearing programmes aim to restore natural ecosystems while retaining the character and recreational appeal of the area.

Flora and Fauna

Cecilia Forest lies within the Cape Floristic Region, one of the world's richest biodiversity hotspots and a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The surrounding fynbos contains extraordinary plant diversity, including proteas, ericas, and restios found nowhere else on Earth.

The forest itself supports birdlife such as Cape sugarbirds, sunbirds, owls, and woodpeckers. Small mammals, reptiles, and numerous insect species also inhabit the area. The streams and damp forest floor create a cool refuge during Cape Town's hot summer months.

Cecilia Forest Today

Modern visitors experience Cecilia Forest as both a natural sanctuary and a cultural landscape shaped by centuries of human interaction. Popular walking routes lead toward landmarks such as Cecilia Waterfall, Rooikat Ravine, and the contour paths of Table Mountain. The forest is especially valued for:

Cool shaded walking trails
Historical plantation scenery
Mountain streams and waterfalls
Access to hiking routes on Table Mountain
Rich birdlife and biodiversity
Peaceful escape from the city

As you walk through Cecilia Forest today, you move through layers of Cape history — indigenous heritage, colonial expansion, forestry, water management, and modern conservation — all set beneath the dramatic slopes of Table Mountain.